

Boarding party
British sailors, armed with cutlasses, and marines, firing muskets, make a hazardous attempt to board a French warship.

TEAM AFLOAT

Once aboard a warship, voluntarily or not, a man took his place as part of a complex, enclosed society over which the captain ruled with almost absolute power. The character of the captain was the key to a happy or unhappy ship. He could make life unbearable for everybody on board, but a captain who cared for his officers and men, whilst maintaining good discipline and order, could form a crew into a highly motivated team in which each man willingly played his part. The sailors were organized into two watches, alternating at their stations to keep the ship manned 24 hours a day. As well as a watch, each sailor belonged to a "mess" of eight to ten men, who ate together and usually formed a bonded group within the crew. Sailors were assigned specific tasks depending on their skills – for example, topmen were those sufficiently nimble and assured to work high on the masts.

LIVING CONDITIONS

A ship was a hard place to live and work. Operating a sailing ship in all weathers exposed men to the constant risk of accidents, which cost many their lives. Cramped living conditions encouraged the spread of disease even on a ship kept spotlessly clean. Disease always killed far more men than combat, especially in unhealthy regions such as the West Indies. Sailors, however, were not badly fed by the standards of their day, with basic rations of salted meat, peas, and dry biscuits ("hard tack"), plus an ample supply of beer and watered rum ("grog"). The tack was unfortunately liable to infestation with weevils and larger grubs known as "bargemen". On a well-run ship sailors would also have some fresh fruit and vegetables and lemon juice to avoid scurvy. Officers ate better than the men because they paid for their own extras supplies.

At sea as ashore, corporal punishment was the means by which order was maintained. In the navy this ranged from "starting" – casual blows with a rope or cane administered to men thought not to be working hard enough – to flogging with the cat o'nine tails and even hanging. Starting was much resented by sailors and was formally abolished in 1809. Flogging was the punishment for a range of offences from drunkenness to sleeping on duty. It was a ritualized procedure carried out by the bosun's mates in front of the whole crew and widely, though not universally, accepted as necessary. Its use could be abused by a sadistic officer, but this was the exception rather than the rule. Hangings were rare. They were the punishment for mutiny, treason, and sodomy – the latter rare on board ships that afforded no privacy. Men's grievances, as expressed in the mutinies of Spithead and the Nore in 1797, tended to focus on issues such as pay being in arrears, the unequal distribution of prize money, the poor quality of food, and lack of shore leave. But a mutiny was above all likely to be provoked by the irrational and unjust behaviour of a specific captain.

COMBAT STATIONS

In the age of Nelson, the quality of Royal Navy sailors was demonstrated time and again. Many operations, such as the blockade of the French ports, were unshowy feats of seamanship, calling for the maintenance of vessels at sea for long periods in all weathers. Actual battles were rare events, but they were ones for which all crews were well prepared. As two opposing warships vied for position in relation to the wind and one another, the guns were manned by their crews and other sailors issued with weapons in order to form or repel a boarding party. The marines, meanwhile, assembled with their muskets, some climbing aloft to act as snipers. Once the captain considered the position right, gun crews would follow a sequence of orders – remove tampions; load and ram; fire; run back the guns – to fire a broadside about once a minute. A ship would continue to engage an enemy even while broadsides fired at close range scattered deadly splinters of wood through the ship like shrapnel, and the surgeon, operating under dreadful conditions below decks, amputated limbs at terrifying speed.

Far from avoiding contact with the enemy, Royal Navy ships actively sought it, driven by the thirst for glory and for prize money. Almost absurd risks were taken to cut out enemy ships in defended harbours or undertake one-on-one actions against heavily gunned opponents. From the boys who carried the cartridges to the guns – hiding them under their jackets so a spark would not ignite the powder and burn their face off – up to the captain who stood on deck amid shot, shell, and falling spar, these were fighting men whose pulses quickened at the scent of battle. By the late period of the Napoleonic Wars they had enabled the Royal Navy to establish an unprecedented dominance of the world's oceans.



The horror of naval warfare
At the battle of the Nile in 1798, the French flagship, *L'Orient (left)*, blew up, killing almost the entire crew. Both sides were so shocked by this catastrophe that they stopped firing for a few minutes.